

User Interview - Understanding the Challenges of a Personal Fitness Trainer

INTERVIEWEE	Sri Hari
OCCUPATION	Personal Fitness Trainer
LOCATION	Bangalore
PURPOSE OF INTERVIEW	To understand the day-to-day challenges faced by an independent personal trainer, particularly in managing clients, schedules, workout records, attendance and payments.

Interview Q&A

Q1. Could you describe your typical working day, from your first session to your last session?

Sri Hari: I usually work seven days a week without a fixed day off. Monday to Friday is particularly hectic. My first session normally starts around 5:15 AM and I continue until around 12:00-12:30 PM. I then get approximately three hours of break before starting again at around 4:00 PM. My evening sessions can continue until around 10:00 PM.

Because of this schedule, most of my day revolves around travelling between locations and training clients.

Q2. How many clients do you currently train, and across how many locations?

Sri Hari: I currently train around 30-40 clients across approximately three locations in Bangalore.

Q3. How do you keep track of who you are training, when you are training them, and what workout they need to do?

Sri Hari: I normally plan my schedule in Excel the previous day. Since I have been training many of my clients for a long time, their regular timings have become part of my routine, so I remember a lot of the schedule in my head.

However, Excel is the main tool I use when I need to plan and keep records.

Q4. If a client asks what workout they did previously, how do you find that information?

Sri Hari: Most clients train around three days a week, and I prepare their workout plans in advance. I usually send the workout chart through WhatsApp and pin it in the client's chat. We then refer to the WhatsApp conversation when following the workout.

Q5. What information about a client's workout is most important for you to track?

Sri Hari: It depends on the client. Many of my clients are above 50 years old and are mainly exercising for general fitness and maintenance rather than bodybuilding or training individual body parts.

For these clients, the important thing is maintaining consistency and ensuring that they continue exercising appropriately rather than strictly tracking body-part-specific workouts.

Q6. How often do missed or cancelled sessions create problems?

Sri Hari: It happens quite often, particularly with older clients. They may become unwell or travel frequently, especially because some are close to retirement.

When clients travel or take long breaks, sessions get postponed and sometimes payments also get delayed. This creates difficulty in managing both my schedule and income.

Q7. How do clients currently pay you? Is it monthly or per session?

Sri Hari: Many existing clients still pay based on a fixed number of sessions. Once they complete those sessions, a new cycle begins.

However, this creates problems when clients take breaks because the payment cycle gets delayed. Because of this, I am gradually moving new clients to a monthly payment model instead of charging them based on sessions.

Q8. How do clients normally make payments?

Sri Hari: Most clients pay through UPI, while a few still pay by cash.

Q9. How do you keep track of whether a client has paid you?

Sri Hari: I mainly track it according to their session cycle. Once all the sessions in a cycle are completed, I remind the client that the next cycle and payment are due.

Most regular clients remember to pay, but I still have to manually keep track of the sessions and payment cycle.

Q10. What happens when a client suddenly cancels a session?

Sri Hari: My schedule can have sessions one after another, sometimes up to around 14 clients in a day. If someone cancels, I contact the client scheduled for the following hour and ask whether they can come earlier.

If they are available, I move their session forward. Otherwise, that time becomes free and I may use it for my own workout or another activity.

This entire rescheduling process is currently handled manually through calls or messages.

Q11. How comfortable are you with apps or software? Have you tried any fitness-management software before?

Sri Hari: I haven't really used dedicated software before. I have searched for apps that could help me track client attendance, workouts and nutrition.

However, I haven't found something that is both user-friendly and affordable. Many of the available apps require monthly or annual subscriptions that I feel are expensive for an individual trainer.

As a result, I continue using Excel and WhatsApp.

Q12. If a system were created specifically for trainers like you, how would it help?

Sri Hari: It would definitely help me and probably many other personal trainers.

Right now, I manage schedules, workout plans and other information using Excel. Sometimes there can be storage issues, files can get corrupted, or information can accidentally disappear. Depending heavily on Excel

and WhatsApp also makes managing everything difficult.

If there were one simple application where trainers could manage their schedules, attendance, workouts, clients and payments, it would be very useful. If the subscription were affordable for individual trainers, I think many trainers would consider using it.

Q13. Is there anything important about working as a personal trainer that I haven't asked about?

Sri Hari: One thing people don't always understand is the amount of personal sacrifice involved.

From the outside, people may think a trainer simply stands next to someone and counts repetitions. In reality, the job requires sacrificing sleep and a lot of personal time.

When friends are meeting or going out, we are often conducting client sessions. Because our busiest times are early mornings and evenings, maintaining a normal social life can become difficult.

At the same time, I enjoy the freedom that comes with the profession. It depends on how you approach the career.

Key Problem Identified

From my interview with Sri Hari, I identified that independent personal trainers lack a simple and affordable system for managing their day-to-day operations.

Sri Hari currently relies on a combination of Excel, WhatsApp, memory, UPI records and manual communication to manage approximately 30-40 clients across multiple locations.

This creates several practical problems:

- Client schedules and last-minute cancellations have to be managed manually.
- Workout plans are scattered between Excel and individual WhatsApp conversations.
- Attendance and completed sessions are difficult to track consistently.
- Session-based payment cycles require manual monitoring and reminders.
- Client travel and cancellations can delay both sessions and payments.
- There is no single place to view a client's schedule, workout history, attendance and payment status.
- Existing software Sri Hari has explored appears either too complicated or too expensive for an independent trainer.
- Heavy dependence on spreadsheets also creates concerns about losing or corrupting information.

Problem Statement

How can I develop a simple, affordable and user-friendly management system for independent personal trainers like Sri Hari that allows them to manage clients, schedules, attendance, workout plans and payments in one place?

The interview indicates that such a system could reduce the amount of administrative work Sri Hari performs manually and allow him to spend more of his time focusing on training and managing his clients.